



Office of
Deputy Commissioner
of Maritime Affairs

THE REPUBLIC OF LIBERIA LIBERIA MARITIME AUTHORITY

Marine Notice

RAD-009
Rev. 08/25

**TO: ALL SHIPOWNERS, OPERATORS, MASTERS AND OFFICERS OF
MERCHANT SHIPS, AGENTS AND RECOGNIZED ORGANIZATIONS**

SUBJECT: Radio Equipment - Emergency Position Indicating Radio Beacon (EPIRB)

Reference:

- (a) Maritime Regulation 2.35
- (b) SOLAS 1978, as amended, Chapter III
- (c) 2009, 1989 and 1979 MODU Codes Chapters 10 and 11
- (d) [MSC.1/Circ.1039/Rev.1](#) - Revised Guidelines for shore-based maintenance of emergency position-indicating radio beacons (EPIRBs)
- (e) [MSC.1/Circ.1040/Rev.2](#) - Revised Guidelines on annual testing of emergency position-indicating radio beacons (EPIRBs)

Supersedes: Marine Notice RAD-009, dated 07/20 and Marine Notice RAD-006, dated 07/20

The following changes have been included:

- a. Marine Notice RAD-006, dated 07/20 has been incorporated into this notice.
- b. New references (d) and (e) have been added and noted in the EPIRB Maintenance Requirement section.
- c. New paragraph 3.4 has been added addressing reporting the activation of an EPIRB to the Administration and previous paragraph 3.4 renumbered to 3.5 and new text added regarding reporting to the Administration.

PURPOSE:

This Notice provides guidance interpretation and clarification of the Liberian Administration's policy regarding EPIRB maintenance, and establishes procedures for programming user protocol, activation, de-activation and disposal of satellite Emergency Position-Indicating Radio Beacon (EPIRB), aboard Liberian Flag vessels.

APPLICABILITY:

This Notice applies to Owners, Masters, Ship Officers and authorized Recognized Organization (RO) (the vessel's Classification Society which has been recognized and authorized to act on behalf of the Liberian Administration) and addresses several SOLAS and MODU Code requirements which have been established by the Office of the Deputy Commissioner.

BACKGROUND:

Distress radio beacons, also known as Emergency Position-Indicating Radio Beacon (EPIRB), are tracking transmitters which aid in the detection and location of boats, aircraft, and people in distress. Strictly, they are radio beacons that interface with worldwide offered service of COSPAS-SARSAT, the international satellite system for search and rescue (SAR). When manually activated, or automatically activated upon immersion, such beacons send out a distress signal. The signals are monitored worldwide, and the location of the distress is detected by non-geostationary satellites and can be located by trilateration in combination with triangulation, respecting the varying quality of the signal received.

REQUIREMENTS:

- 1.0** Every ship shall be provided with a satellite EPIRB which shall be:
 - 1.1 capable of transmitting a distress alert through the polar orbiting satellite service operating in the 406 MHz band;
 - 1.2 installed in an easily accessible position;
 - 1.3 ready to be manually released and capable of being carried by one person into a survival craft;
 - 1.4 capable of floating free if the ship sinks and of being automatically activated when afloat; and
 - 1.5 capable of being activated manually.
- 2.0** Ships engaged on voyages exclusively in sea area A1 may carry, in lieu of the satellite EPIRB required by sub-paragraph 1.1 above, an EPIRB capable of transmitting a distress alert using DSC on VHF channel 70 and providing for locating by means of a radar transponder operating in the 9 GHz band.
- 3.0** Upon acquiring a (new) EPIRB:
 - 3.1 Every 406 MHz EPIRB must be programmed/coded with two key items of information:
 - .1 The first item of information is the Maritime Identification Digits (MID) assigned to The Republic of Liberia by the International Telecommunication Union, Geneva. This three-digit code is 636 – followed by;
 - .2 The second item of information is the trailing six digits of the ship's Maritime Mobile Service Identification number (MMSI)
 - 3.2 This coding must be adhered to by the supplier of satellite EPIRBs being installed on board Liberian flag vessels.
 - 3.3 Each Beacon has a Unique Beacon Identifier (UBI or HEX ID). The Hex ID is a 15 hexadecimal character string (valid range: numbers 0 through 9 and letters A through F), referred to as the beacon 15 Hex Identification, or 15 Hex ID. The beacon's 15-character Hex ID uniquely identifies the 406 MHz beacon and is encoded in the message the beacon transmits to search and rescue services when the beacon is activated. When the beacon is activated, satellites will detect the transmission and relay the distress alert to search and rescue services.

The Hex ID is found on a label affixed to the beacon or in the beacon documentation provided by the beacon manufacturer.

- 3.4 The EPIRB Hex ID number for every EPIRB activated on a vessel, including EPIRBs installed in lifesaving craft, VDRs, or other ship apparatus, must be reported to the Administration whenever a vessel is registered or re-registered under the Liberian flag as part of the application for a Ship Radio Station license. EPIRB Hex ID information shall also be submitted to the Administration whenever a new or replacement EPIRB is installed and activated on a vessel. Such submission shall be sent vesselcertifications@liscr.com.
- 3.5 When an Application for a Ship Radio Station license has been completed and a permanent Ship Radio Station License issued, or when the Administration is informed of the activation of a new or replacement EPIRB, the Administration will facilitate the registration of the vessels EPIRB into the International Beacon Registration Database (IBRD).

4.0 EPIRB Maintenance Requirements

Satellite EPIRBS shall be:

- 4.1 annually tested for all aspects of operational efficiency, with a special emphasis on checking the emission on operational frequencies, coding and registration and in accordance with provided in [MSC.1/Circ.1040/Rev.2](#), at intervals as specified below:
- .1 on passenger ships, within three months before the expiry date of the Passenger Ship Safety Certificate; and
 - .2 on cargo ships, within three months before the expiry date, or three months before or after the anniversary date of the Cargo Ship Safety Radio Certificate.
- 4.2 subject to maintenance at intervals not exceeding five years, to be performed at an approved shore-based maintenance facility, and in accordance with provided in [MSC.1/Circ.1039/Rev.1](#).

5.0 De-activation and disposal

- 5.1 If a EPIRB is lost, damaged, destroyed or otherwise rendered unusable and the beacon is replaced, the new beacon's 15 Hex ID must be submitted to the Administration and amended on the Ship Radio Station License. The Administration will facilitate the deletion and de-activation of the 'old' beacon's 15 Hex ID from the IBRD and replace it with the new beacon's Hex ID.
- 5.2 When a vessel leaves the Registry, the Administration will facilitate the de-activation of the EPIRB in the IBRD.
- 5.3 If the vessel is sold to a new Owner, the new owner will re-code/re-program the EPIRB with updated key items of information.

- 5.4 If the vessel is scrapped and the EPIRB is left onboard, all data held in the beacon must be erased to avoid accidental transmission of distress signals.
- 5.5 When disposing of an EPIRB, batteries must be disconnected and all data erased to avoid accidental transmission of distress signals.
- 5.6 A record of the method of disposal of an EPIRB shall be maintained on board the vessel or if the vessel has been scrapped or sold in the offices of the company responsible for the operation of the vessel.

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